STEPPE

Go-to-Market & Organizing Plan

Growth through programs

REDMOND · CENTRAL OREGON · EST. 2026

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A member-governed Oregon public benefit nonprofit.

Steppe --- Go-to-Market & Organizing Plan

v1.2 · July 2026 · supersedes v1.1. v1.2 adds "How this plan changes" (the kernel/emergence rule from the doctrine assessment); v1.1 was an editorial voice pass — no strategy changed in either. Fiscal-sponsor status: **Ignite Empowerment Foundation** selected (Central Oregon 501(c)(3)); agreement pending signature — see `docs/sponsors-programmatic-partners-landscape.md`.

Framing

This is an organizing plan, not a marketing plan. A member-owned, verification-gated, ad-refusing civic institution recruited through broadcast advertising would contradict its own thesis on day one. The medium has to match the message. That rules out paid acquisition permanently and makes **trust transferred through real people** the primary channel at every stage. The constraint is also the most credible story Steppe has: the way it grows is itself proof of what it is.

Three things follow from that and govern everything below:

- **Place-anchored, not founder-anchored.** Every public moment should read as a Redmond thing that Greg helped start, never a Greg thing that happens to be in Redmond. Partners co-front; the founder recedes.
- **Programs are the best marketing.** Once the work is real, the work is the pitch. Steppe Connect and the Net Inclusion case study generate legitimacy that loops back into local trust faster than any messaging could.
- **Transparency is an asset no competitor can copy.** Near-total financial openness is a structural differentiator. A competitor can match a feature; it cannot match an ownership structure without restructuring. Lead with the structure.

Hard dependency: Phase 1 cannot begin until the funnel works. The production DB rebuild, the `interest_signups` write, the Resend confirmation email, and the member-app un-gate must all be live before any public push. Marketing into a dead form burns the warmest contacts first. Fix the pipe, then open the tap.

The non-negotiables

These hold across all phases. A tactic that violates one of them undermines the thesis even if it "works."

1. **No paid acquisition, ever.** No ads, no boosted posts, no incentivized-referral growth hacks. Vouching is social, not transactional.
2. **The structure is the hook, the app is secondary.** Lead with: you own this, it can't be sold, it answers to members, $4/month flat, no ads, your data is yours, decisions are reversible. Features come after.
3. **Some things are deliberately not marketed.** The Tribal Digital Sovereignty work is governed by partners' sovereignty — including over their own visibility. Steppe does not market on Indigenous partnerships. The work speaks; partners choose what is said and when.
4. **Congruence is the test.** Before running any tactic, ask: is this consistent with member ownership, locality, and verification? If it only works by quietly contradicting one of those,

it's the wrong tactic.

Phase 0 --- Seeding (now, pre-launch)

Objective: Have 50–100 people on the interest list *before* the public moment, so launch day shows a room that's already full.

The inaugural cohort should feel chosen, not solicited. That's what converts an early member into an owner rather than a user. Recruit the founding nucleus by hand, through the people who already have standing in Redmond.

Tactics

- **Give every partner a concrete ask, not a vague one.** Holli through Redmond Compass, Brandon through Herringbone's customers, plus warm contacts at COCC, OSU-Cascades, and any neighborhood-association leads. The ask is specific: *personally bring ten people you'd vouch for.* Ten each across the board candidates and close partners gets you most of the way to the nucleus.
- **One honest page, not a pitch deck.** Partners need something forwardable that sounds like Steppe — plain, direct, structural. A glossy deck would be off-brand. A clear one-pager explaining what it is, what it costs, and why it can't be sold is the artifact.
- **Pre-write the welcome sequence before the first signup lands.** The Resend confirmation is the first touch and sets the tone for the whole relationship. It should sound like a civic institution welcoming a member-owner, not a SaaS onboarding email. Draft it now so the funnel doesn't go live with a placeholder.
- **Segment the list as it forms.** Tag captain candidates (people with networks and standing in a neighborhood) separately from general members. Phase 2 runs on captains; identify them early.

Health signals: interest-list size; share of contacts sourced through partners vs. cold; number of credible captain candidates surfaced.

Phase 1 --- Inaugural Launch (when the member app un-gates)

Objective: Convert the nucleus plus a first public wave into a founding cohort that immediately *does something* — governs a real decision — so membership feels like ownership on day one.

Message architecture

Lead with ownership and permanence. *Redmond owns this. It cannot be sold. It answers to its members.* The $4/month, the no-ads commitment, the member-controlled data, and the can't-be-enshittified structure are the hook. Tie it to something residents already feel — broadband gaps, civic disconnection, distrust of platforms that change the deal once you're locked in. The Doctorow frame (the platform that decays once it owns you) lands here precisely because everyone has lived it; Steppe's answer is structural ownership, not a promise to be nice.

Tactics

- **A physical launch at Herringbone.** Brandon's space, a board candidate, a natural Redmond gathering point. Partners co-host so it reads as civic, not personal. The event is the moment;

the digital push follows it, not the reverse.

- **Press, on the founder-institution angle.** *Local professor builds a civic institution Redmond actually owns* is the strongest pitch — concrete, local, slightly surprising. Targets: The Bulletin, KTVZ, Central Oregon Daily, the Source Weekly (the alt-weekly civic angle fits well), and the Redmond community press. Before pitching, confirm which outlets are currently active and who covers civic life and technology. Pitch the story as about *residents*, not about software.
- **Give the cohort a real first vote.** The single best launch tactic is to hand the founding members something genuine to decide in their first week — a Community Fund seed allocation, a name, a neighborhood-priority ranking. A membership that votes on day one is real in a way that a membership that waits cannot be. This is the launch's center of gravity, not a footnote.
- **Activate the list in sequence, not all at once.** Event → press hits → list activation → first decision opens. Each step feeds the next and gives the press something live to point at.

What to refuse here: no paid launch ads, no countdown-timer urgency, no growth hacks. The launch's credibility *is* its restraint.

Health signals: event attendance; press pickups; conversion of nucleus + wave into founding members; participation in the first vote (this is the one that matters most — it measures whether membership feels real).

Phase 2 --- Neighborhood Saturation (launch → 2027)

Objective: Grind patiently toward ~2,300 members (~6.5% of Redmond), the threshold that funds the comp ceiling at $4/month. This is the long phase, and it's organizing, not campaigning.

The captains model

Turn Redmond's 35 neighborhoods into 35 organizing units, each with a member who vouches for and onboards their block. This mirrors Steppe's subsidiarity design and the verification-by-vouching model — growth happens through relationship and local standing, not spend. It is the single most important Phase 2 structure.

One caution from the project's own canon: a pure captains-by-vibes arrangement will reproduce exactly the failure Jo Freeman named — informal structure that quietly concentrates power in whoever has the most time and the loudest voice. Captains need *light, explicit* structure: a clear, simple charge, a defined onboarding flow, and a known way to hand the role off. Not bureaucracy — legibility. Enough mētis to stay human, enough épistēmē to stay fair.

Tactics

- **Build the captain onboarding flow as a real artifact.** What a captain does, how they vouch, how they welcome a new member, how they pass the baton. Worth doing properly — this is the engine of the whole phase.
- **Member stories are the only content engine.** "Why I joined," in members' own words. This is on-brand precisely because it is not advertising — it's testimony from owners. Authentic, repeatable, and impossible to fake at scale. Let it be the entire content program; resist the urge to manufacture anything glossier.
- **Physical presence over digital spend.** Table at the places Redmond already gathers — farmers market, library, Compass events, Herringbone. Show up in person. A booth where

someone can ask a real human "wait, I *own* this?" converts better than any feed.

- **Post the numbers publicly.** Member count, dues collected, comp paid. Radical transparency as recruitment: the meter running in the open is itself the pitch, and it makes the $4 $\longrightarrow$ comp-ceiling logic visible rather than asserted.
- **Vouching, not incentivized referral.** Members bring members because they believe in it and stake their standing on it — congruent with verification. A referral bounty would be the growth-hack version and would cheapen the thing. Keep it social.

Health signals: member count toward 2,300 (a genuine outcome — it's the funding condition, not a vanity number); neighborhoods with an active captain; quorum-level participation (the 15% floor) holding as the base grows; volume of member stories coming in unprompted.

Phase 3 --- Program Legitimacy (2027)

Objective: Let the programs prove the mission. As Steppe Connect launches and the Net Inclusion case study lands, marketing shifts from *describing* Steppe to *demonstrating* it — and national legitimacy loops back into local trust.

Tactics

- **Steppe Connect as an earned-media generator.** Rural broadband is a press-friendly, human story with obvious stakes. The program arm (grant-funded, 2027+) gives outlets something concrete and sympathetic to cover, and it positions Steppe as a builder of infrastructure, not just a membership app.
- **Net Inclusion 2027 (Columbus, Feb 23–25) as the national moment.** If the workshop is accepted, the applied session with Steppe as case study puts it in front of the digital-inclusion community that confers legitimacy in this space. That recognition travels home: Redmonders join faster when the thing they're joining is respected elsewhere. On acceptance, the next step is building the session deck from the existing workshop outline.
- **The annual report as a flagship asset.** The radically-transparent report is a marketing artifact in its own right. Full financials, no funder over 30%, comp disclosed — published openly. No competitor can run this play without restructuring, which is exactly why it works.
- **Position the thesis in the discourse, carefully.** The founder's writing and speaking on structural ownership — the Ostrom commons frame, Baradaran on who owns what, the Hirschman point that Steppe solves enshittification through *ownership* rather than *exit* — situates the project in the civic-tech conversation and draws the funders and peers who matter. Keep this in a separate channel from local recruitment (see "the two-narratives problem" below).
- **Conference pipeline as listening and legitimacy:** Platform Cooperativism Consortium (philosophical fit), the U.S. Indigenous Data Sovereignty Summit in Tucson (low travel cost given UA affiliation; listening posture).

The Tribal work stays off the marketing surface. This is a firm line, not a soft preference. The Tribal Digital Sovereignty Program and the Warm Springs relationship are governed by the partners' sovereignty, including over visibility. Steppe does not put Indigenous partnerships on a slide to borrow credibility. The work proceeds; what is said about it, and when, belongs to the partners.

Health signals: earned-media reach and quality; conference outcomes (peers reached, follow-ups); grant-pipeline influence; whether national recognition produces measurable local signups.

Phase 4 --- Institutional Maturity & Replication (2028+)

Objective: Mature from a project into an institution, and reframe "growth" as movement-building rather than customer acquisition. Redmond done right is the whole pitch.

Tactics

- **Government funding, handled in the open.** When public money enters (2028+, radically transparent), the transparency *is* the story. "We took government funding and here's every dollar, in public" is a credibility-builder, not a risk to manage — provided no single funder crosses 30%.
- **Replication as narrative, not sales.** Other communities are a movement, not a market. The 12-community hard cap means this is never customer acquisition — it's the proof that the model is real and the deliberate refusal to scale past what stays governable. The cap is itself a thing to talk about: chosen smallness as an ethic, the opposite of the growth logic everyone else is running.
- **Durability as marketing.** As the founder-protection period sunsets (5–7 years) and the founder's role transitions to the advisory seat, the story becomes *it doesn't depend on one person.* An institution that survives its founder is more trustworthy than one that doesn't, and saying so plainly is good marketing for the structure.
- **The annual report as a recurring moment.** Each year's transparent report is a flagship release — a predictable, on-brand beat that compounds.

Health signals: funder diversification (no funder >30%); replication inquiries from other communities; institutional durability indicators (board health, leadership transition readiness).

Phase 5 --- Long Horizon (2029, Warm Springs)

This phase is anti-marketing, and that is the point. The Warm Springs relationship is a 2029 horizon held in a listening posture: show up, listen, don't sell, don't publicize. Trust is the entire deliverable, built over years without a campaign. The discipline here is the refusal to treat a relationship as a channel. Everything about how Steppe approaches this is itself a statement about what kind of institution it is.

The two-narratives problem

There is a real strategic risk to manage from Phase 3 onward, and it ties to the unresolved 501(c)(3) mission-scope tension. Steppe has two stories aimed at two audiences:

- **The local story** (members): *Redmond owns this.* Hyper-local, concrete, structural. This is the recruitment narrative and it must stay clean.
- **The civic-tech story** (funders, conferences, other communities): *a replicable model for community-owned civic infrastructure.* Broader, more abstract, movement-flavored.

If these bleed, the local message muddies — a Redmond resident does not want to hear about a national civic-tech movement; they want to know who owns the thing in their town. Keep them in separate channels with separate framing. The local site, events, and press stay relentlessly about Redmond. The thesis writing, conference talks, and funder materials carry the broader story. Resolve which lane the articles and the 501(c)(3) filing commit to *before* filing, because that legal choice constrains which story the organization can tell.

What we deliberately do not do

A short list, because what Steppe refuses defines the brand as much as what it does:

- No paid advertising of any kind, at any stage.
- No incentivized or bounty-based referral.
- No urgency manufacturing — countdowns, false scarcity, "spots running out."
- No marketing on Tribal or Indigenous partnerships.
- No growth-tier features promised at MVP to chase momentum (the month-grid calendar problem — keep scope discipline under marketing pressure).
- No analytics surveillance of members to optimize conversion (the no-Google-Analytics line holds; it stays).

How this plan changes (deliberate kernel, emergent edges)

This plan is deliberately Rumelt-shaped — diagnosis, guiding policy, coherent phased action — and it stays that way. But the two layers of it change under different rules (see `docs/steppe-governable-spaces-emergent-strategy-v1.md`, Part IV):

- **The kernel is deliberate.** The framing diagnosis, the guiding policy (trust-through-real-people as the only channel; structure-is-the-hook), and the four non-negotiables change only the way the constitution changes: openly, versioned, and — where they touch member commitments — by the members.
- **The tactics are hypotheses.** Every phase's *health signals are its falsification instruments*: if captains stall, if the first vote draws no one, if member stories don't come unprompted, the tactic is wrong — not the members. Patterns observed in action get promoted into this document (a version bump, changelog noted) or discarded at the reflection cadence and phase gates; they are never patched silently.
- **"Congruence is the test" polices the boundary in both directions.** Emergence never erodes the kernel; the kernel never freezes the tactics.

Immediate next actions

1. **Clear the funnel blockers.** DB rebuild from canonical `schema.sql` + signup migration, Resend confirmation wired, member-app un-gate. Nothing public ships before this.
2. **Draft the welcome email** in Steppe's voice before the funnel goes live.
3. **Give each partner the specific ask** (bring ten vouched people) and the one honest page to forward.
4. **Design the founding cohort's first vote** — the single most important launch decision.
5. **Build the captain onboarding flow** as a real artifact ahead of Phase 2.

Living document. Each version supersedes the last.